Hard Magic and Soft Magic in Chronicles of Darkness



Heavy Arms
Banned

Join Date: Nov 2013
Posts: 12634

Share
Post

02-21-2018, 03:18 PM #16

> *Originally posted by* ***Morangias***
> *Sorry, but that's just wrong. I don't really have any argument to back it up, because it's blindingly obvious that Endowments are functional magic meant to be directly applied to problems.*

The problem is that you're not thinking in the terms of narrative problems, but in terms of RPG style "problem solving." @Charlaquin has gone in to significant detail to the need to consider Sanderson's starting point (writing fiction) and how to translate that to RPGs, rather that following the "letter" of his laws vs. the "spirit" of them

> *Magic being a tool is, again, a staple of hard magic systems.*

It's also a staple of soft magic systems to make them narratively accessible The idea is simple: give the reader something that's a bit more hard so they can understand it, even as they recognize that it slots into a wider soft magic world. Again, Excalibur, the One Ring, and so on are basic examples of such things: undeniably soft magic systems which generate plot important magic for the protagonists that works a bit more hard style to give it limitations and tension that are otherwise difficult to establish in soft magic systems.

> *And - again - according to Sanderson himself, the origins of magic are the last thing that matters. We don't need to know how Cheiron does their stuff, as long as their stuff produces reliable, quantifiable results.*

But they still matter.

Also Cheiron doesn't produce reliable, quantifiable results. Their best results are just what they put out in the field. We've even been teased with the idea that Cheirons less successful attempts could easily create a Renegade from Deviant

instead of a stable field agent.

> *And yes, as long as magic in a roleplaying game is described with a set of game rules, it is hard magic.*

This stance is clearly incompatible with the entire concept Sanderson is trying to express. Again, see above post for why.

> *...because the gist of Sanderson's Law is that in a soft magic setting, magic becomes an asspull and you don't want your story conflict to be solved by asspulls.*

No, it really isn't. The point of examining hard vs. soft magic is to recognize the strengths and weaknesses of each, and know how to write to get the most out of them. Magic being an asspull in a soft magic system is bad writing that doesn't play to soft magic's strengths well, not something inherent to soft magic.

> *...okay, let's put it differently: what do **you** think is missing from Endowments to classify them as hard magic? I've already shown that their overall power/efficiency level doesn't count.*

1) I'm not say all Endowments and minor templates are soft magic, I'm saying those groups are the where you'll find the most soft magic oriented parts of the CofD.

2) "Power efficiency" is a strawman you're bringing in. It only matters to my point in the narrative role things like Endowments play. An Endowment's narrative role is to boost a Hunter's power to a point where they can engage with more potent supernatural threats, not any sort of analysis of how much power it grants compared to Disciplines. An Endowment's efficiency is also part of it's narrative role. Arsenal is more reliable than Thaumatech for narrative reasons, and how unreliable an Endowment is, is part of how hard or soft it comes off as.

3) I'm talking about magic systems, which is more than Endowments alone, but the entire magical system an Endowment operates in. This is the most important part of what seems to be lacking in your points. The Endowments exist in a very soft magical system, even if some individual Endowments can be on the hard side. What's "missing" is that because the mechanics of an RPG are not reality simulators, but resolution mechanics, they aren't actually dictating the truth of the setting. Thus we need to look at the rest of the rules, not just the mechanics, which includes things like, say, Cheiron groups rather low success rate at implantations that are worth putting in the field. One of the "rules" of Hunter is that Thaumatech is dangerous and unreliable because it's poorly understood, which is a soft magic system.

> *I'm not saying CofD is 100% hard. What I am saying is, you picked a wrong example to show its softer side.*

And I don't think you've managed to really demonstrate this.

👍 3 Quote Flag

Font Size

Write something...

Cancel Preview Post Reply

English (US) HELP | CONTACT US | GO TO TOP

Copyright Onyx Path Publishing LLC and individual users. Exalted, the Chronicles of Darkness, and the World of Darkness copyright Paradox Interactive AB.
Powered by vBulletin® Version 6.2.4
Copyright © 2026 MH Sub I, LLC dba vBulletin. All rights reserved.
All times are GMT-7. This page was generated at 10:12 AM.